

DOES MAGIC EXIST?

This bewitching subject means different things to different people. For some, magic is purely a spectacle in which magicians create the illusion of having special powers for a captive audience. However, most people understand that they have not really conjured a rabbit from a hat, cut a woman in half, or made someone disappear in a puff of smoke. Instead, these magicians have learned their trade and practiced their tricks for years in order to perfect their stage performances.

SUPERNATURAL POWERS

Magic in a supernatural sense is another story. In ancient times, there were people considered to be magic makers in Greece, Egypt, and Italy. Society held them in high esteem, believing that these witches and wizards were blessed with supernatural powers. Magic makers would harness the power of nature, recite chants, prepare potions, and carry out spells in order to heal the sick or injured, bring about good luck, or, occasionally, create curses. Many cultures viewed them as wise ones, and they would be summoned to perform their magic to help the wider community by healing health problems and influencing the weather to produce better crops.

WITCH TRIALS

Magic makers did not always prove popular, though. While some religions accepted the belief and use of magic,

others rejected it outright as the devil's work on Earth. This came to a head in the 1600s, when the Christian Church decided that magic was satanic, and so magic makers should be punished, tortured, and killed for their craft. Self-appointed witch-hunters traveled across Europe, making wild accusations based on little or no evidence. In 1692, a village called Salem in Massachusetts was the scene of multiple deaths when a group of village girls accused local people of being witches. It resulted in 141 arrests and 20 executions.

TODAY'S MAGIC

Despite the turbulent events of the past, some cultures still believe in magic and encourage its practice. Voodoo (magic of West African origin) and shamanism (witchcraft with a spiritual emphasis) continue today, using a mix of the forces of nature and contact with spirits to make magic. Some tribal communities in parts of Africa keep with tradition and have a shaman (spiritual leader) who is believed to possess magical powers that are used to benefit the whole community. Bubbling cauldrons may no longer be involved, but forms of alternative medicine remain popular, with nature's ingredients used in specific combinations to cure ailments and illnesses. Though it appears in a variety of guises, magic can bring positive changes or, at the very least, add a little bit of sparkle to everyone's lives.